



TIPS & TRICKS

An alternative for the `dd` command

We are comfortable using the `dd` command in our day to day administration of computers and servers. An alternative to it is the `dcfldd` command, which also shows a progress report of the process. `dcfldd` is an enhanced version of `dd`, developed by the US Department of Defence Computer Forensics Lab.

To use `dcfldd`, we first need to install it, for which you can use the following command:

```
$sudo apt-get install dcfldd
```

```
$dcfldd if=<source> of=<destination>
```

For example:

```
$dcfldd if=/dev/zero of=/dev/null
```

The output is:

```
425216 blocks (1328MB) written.
```

—Rupin Puthukudi, rupinmp@gmail.com

A beginner's guide to Curl

The `Curl` command is used to transfer data from or to a server. It is used with the following protocols: HTTP, HTTPS, FTP, SFTP, TFTP, DICT, TELNET, LDAP, IMAP, SCP, SMTP and SMTPS.

Curl can be used inside the scripts. When you download using the `Curl` command, you can easily pause or resume the download. There are 120 command line options with the `Curl` command. It supports cookies, forms and SSL, multiple uploads with a single command and IPv6.

For example:

```
$curl http://www.my.org
```

The above command shows the contents of this website in your terminal. If you want to save the output of the `Curl` command, you can use the redirect symbol `>` or the `-o` option.

For example:

```
$curl http://www.centos.org > file.txt
```

...or:

```
$curl http://www.centos.org -o file.txt
```

Now let's look at how to download multiple files using the `Curl` command:

```
$curl -O http://ftp.open.com/pub/axt.html -O http://ftp.gnu.com/pub/bxy.html -O http://ftp.lkj.com/pub/c.html
```

An important fact to note here is that `Curl` will use the same TCP connection to download multiple files. This is done to improve the download speed. When we use `Curl -O` (uppercase O), it will save the contents in the file with the original file name in the local machine. If we use `-o` (lowercase o), then we need to give the file name in the command.

Curl is automatically redirected to a new URL if we use the `-L` option.

For example:

```
$curl -L google.com
```

After running the above command, you can cancel the downloading process using `Ctrl+c`, and then if we want to resume downloading from the last point, use the `-C` option.

```
$curl -C - -O http://ftp.local.com/pub/test.gz
```

```
** Resuming transfer from byte position 28609
```

```
% Total % Received % Xferd Average Speed Time Time Time Current
```

To limit the data rate in the `Curl` command, use the `--limit-rate` option, as follows:

```
$curl --limit-rate 1000B -O http://ftp.local.com/pub/test.gz
```